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Submitter Information

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General Comment

I'm writing to express my profound objection to the terms of the AI Action Plan requested by Google and OpenAI, as well as my broader disappointment at the mercenary behavior of the tech sector and the enabling federal actions which have been put forth in response. The suspension of intellectual property restrictions to enable AI scraping would devastate my life as a writer and a designer, robbing me of my ability to make an honest living and permanently tarnishing my trust in the federal government's ability to responsibly manage AI technology.

Traditionally, people like me sustain ourselves through lean times by writing articles on contract or doing gig work. AI tools which expressly attempt to eliminate writers and designers are being heavily promoted, and of course, they are developed by stealing work which my peers and I work tirelessly to create for a pittance. This is no longer feasible, as work has dried up. Not only are many websites running machine-generated copy instead of human writing, but entire fake publications are being generated with AI. The floor has been torn out from underneath us, and everyone I know, regardless of age, occupation, or politics, is scared. If the action plan is accepted, I would feel sufficiently uneasy about my prospects in the creative sector that I would feel forced to search for work in an entirely different field or country.

The narrative promoted by companies such as OpenAI and Google is that their AI tools are already a part of life, and we all just need to adopt it. But this isn't true, and as creative workers, we do not even have anything to gain from using the AI tools illegally trained on our work and our sensitive personal information[1], because the resulting outputs are often viewed as inferior, dishonest, and off-putting to many of our audiences[2], and the demand for creative work of all kinds has not increased, so we would be accomplishing nothing but diminishing ourselves. It is a nightmarish situation that this Action Plan would only exacerbate.

My friends and colleagues are profoundly upset at what we believe to be simply an attempt to eradicate jobs and consolidate wealth. This appears to be the case all across the country. AXIOS reported one year ago[3] that in America, trust in AI companies was as low as 38% among Democrats and 24% among Republicans, and last June[4] that about two-thirds of Gen Z used AI only very rarely or not at all, and 41% of Gen Z had never used AI tools for any purpose.

Our resentments are not frivolous, they drive my generation's (already very nervous) economic activity. I've stopped using several social media and portfolio sites, and dramatically decreased my time spent online because AI content is meaningless and unnerving and it's upsetting that nothing I see is provably real. This means I'm exposed to a fraction of the online advertising I would previously see. My purchasing has also significantly declined, and unethical AI utilization has driven me from brands like Adobe which I'd previously been devoted to for years.

It would take a huge change in circumstances for me to resume that level of financial engagement, and the Action Plan would discourage me from creating new creative works because without intellectual property enforcement, doing so would put me at risk of exploitation by AI companies. I believe an unregulated AI sector would have a freezing effect on economic activity much more widely, for reasons similar to mine.

There is not any one amendment to the proposed legislation that would assuage my concerns, besides it's unequivocal rejection. At the very least, existing intellectual property rights need to be upheld and strengthened, and representatives from the creative fields need to be involved in any future deliberations that would involve our futures. The AI industry has failed to produce miracles when provided with not only a galaxy of public domain data but the stolen wealth of potentially nearly every American citizen. It is not the responsibility of American creatives to bear the burden of the tech sector's continuing failures. It is the responsibility of the American government to bring

the rank ambition of these companies to heel before they ruin us.

[1] <https://arstechnica.com/tech-policy/2024/06/ai-trained-on-photos-from-kids-entire-childhood-without-their-consent/>

[2] <https://www.rollingstone.com/culture/culture-features/ai-image-brand-backlash-1235040371/>

[3] <https://www.axios.com/2024/03/05/ai-trust-problem-edelman>

[4] <https://www.axios.com/2024/06/03/ai-teens-young-adults-survey>